



DELHI | Sweet Nothings

Sugar just doesn't taste that sweet any more at Krishi Bhavan. Under attack from both the Opposition and UPA allies, the Grand Maratha is in the midst of a political and existential crisis. At the heart of the problem is simple economics—right now, sugar supply is less than the demand. The resultant higher prices—now at Rs 50 per kg and rising—translates into a political problem. Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar, often accused of manipulating sugar cultivation, processing and pricing to enlarge his vote base in the sugar districts of Maharashtra, is for the first time frazzled by the relentless scrutiny. A fatigued Pawar said, "I am not an astrologer to predict when prices will fall." This caused the BJP to instantly bay for his resignation. A defensive Pawar then blamed the Uttar Pradesh Government, saying that Mayawati has banned processing of imported raw sugar, due to which raw sugar was held up at Kandla port for over two months. He said, "The Uttar Pradesh Government is not allowing millers to process sugar. This would have helped bridge the supply-demand gap and brought prices down." Mayawati shot back at the "insensitive statements" and "faulty economic, import and export policies". The translation of economics into politics was predictable, but blaming Mayawati earned Pawar some Congress applause and his not so just dessert. *by Priya Sahgal*

**PAWAR (ABOVE)
BLAMES
MAYAWATI FOR
THE SUGAR
CRISIS**

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million tonnes will be India's shortfall of sugar in 2010. Prices are now driven to a dizzy high of Rs 50 per kg.